

Ecclesiastical Trench Art - The Somme Crosses of the Durham Light Infantry

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While it most commonly appears in the form of decorated brass artillery shell cases, trench art embraces a wide array of material and its creation takes inspiration from a range of human impulses. This article examines the trench art memorial crosses of the Durham Light Infantry commemorating one of the closing actions of the Somme campaign of the Great War. Originally marking the site of heavy regimental losses, the surviving memorials have been translated to Durham Cathedral and local county parish churches. The dynamics and motivations of the crosses' creators are explored along with the impact such pieces may have had on the landscape they once dominated. The crosses exemplify the ephemeral nature of such memorials, as well their evolving narratives, as successive generations seek a locus for remembrance.

Introduction

First World War trench art¹, the recyclica of the war to end all wars, is often small, portable and anonymous. Thousands of decorated artillery shell cases and other ephemera of war may have long-since lost their context, their narratives of origin and family possession becoming more inaccessible with each passing generation. Yet each piece is associated through its material, its manufacture, and its use with human experience (Saunders 2003a, Kimball 2004). It is a by-product of conflict and is imbued with a social agency through its function as souvenir, memorial, utilitarian object, or decorative item (Saunders 2003a, 221-223). Such artefacts can also be highly ambiguous, depending upon the circumstances of their manufacture (Isyanova 2009, 132). While introducing the Somme crosses of the Durham Light Infantry (DLI) as a form of trench art, this paper explores the wider dynamics behind the creation of these unusual, if not unique, examples. What stimulated this kind of memorial and can we legitimately ascribe to it properties of agency, that is “an ability to act to some effect in a particular context” (Robb 2010, 513)? Of the 700,000 who visit Durham Cathedral each year few perhaps will notice the cross in the DLI Chapel in

the south transept (Figure 1). Created from military timbers with a plinth probably made from packing cases, at a height of 9 feet (2.74m) and a span of almost 4 feet (1.22m), the cross will be one of the larger pieces of trench art in the country. Standing as a focus of commemoration, it serves as a witness to events on the Western Front in 1916 and also as a contemporary medium for personal negotiation with conflict and loss, the plinth being decorated with miniature crosses, poppies, cards, and rubber wristbands.

The cross's status as trench art is secure. A scroll mounted behind the cross confirms that it was made by DLI pioneers from material probably provided by the Royal Engineers. The stem and arms are from timbers, the type of which would have been used for a wide range of functions, from trench revetting, to gun emplacements or route building purposes (Macdonald 2013, 126). The upper storey of the plinth bears hinge marks suggesting it may originally may have been an ammunition box, and is strikingly similar to recycled wood used to signpost ‘Hellfire Corner’, a key point on the Menin Road in the Ypres Salient (Figure 2). The scroll also explains that the cross originally stood on a feature called the Butte de Warlencourt, site of one of the closing engagements of the Somme campaign of 1916.



Fig 1
The Butte de Warlencourt Cross in the DLI Chapel, Durham Cathedral. (Author. By kind permission of the Chapter of Durham Cathedral.)

The Battle of the Somme concluded in mid-November 1916 with the capture of the strongpoint of Beaumont Hamel. This had been an early and vital objective in the northern sector when the battle opened on 1 July, a reach of about a thousand yards. Further to the south the allies had enjoyed a greater degree of territorial success, eventually penetrating about 6 miles towards Warlencourt by the close of the campaign. Ultimately, the Butte de Warlencourt remained just within the enemy's possession until it was abandoned in early 1917 as the Germans withdrew to the Hindenburg Line (Hart 2006, 58-132, 486-497, 500-531). The Butte was then selected as a site of commemoration (WS 1).

After almost 10 years on the Butte, the cross was brought to Durham and erected in the Cathedral in 1927. Suffering from the effects of the weather, the cross may have become increasingly redundant in a landscape being transformed by the commemorative styles of Lutyens and Blomfield, and the Imperial War Graves Commission. The cross has at least two companion pieces, currently in the parish churches of



Fig 2
A wooden container lid used to mark Hell Fire Corner. (© National Army Museum 83391)

St Mary and St Cuthbert, Chester-Le-Street, and St Andrew's, Bishop Auckland. A fourth cross, probably a prototype for the others, was displayed in the DLI Museum in Durham before its closure in 2016. It commemorated those of 9 DLI who fell at High Wood in September and October 1916, and was similarly displayed in the parish church of Gateshead, St Mary The Virgin (Smith 1954) before it closed in 1979.

The crosses possess not only a close association with actions on the Somme and the Durham Light Infantry; they appear to be largely the inspiration of one remarkable man, Lieutenant (and soon to be temporary Brigadier) Roland Bradford, VC, MC, commanding officer of 9 DLI during the Warlencourt action.

The Durhams on the Somme Sep-Nov 1916

The 6th, 8th and 9th Battalions of the DLI, comprising the 151st (Durham) Brigade of the 50th (Northumbrian) Division, were heavily involved in the actions which saw vital territorial gains towards the end of 1916, sometimes even described as the Great Advance (Smith, 1954). From mid-September progress was made from the bitterly-contested High Wood to Eaucourt l'Abbaye where Roland Bradford, at the age of 24, took command of two battalions (the other commanding officer having been wounded), rallied a faltering attack and secured their objective. For his fearless energy and skilful leadership, he was awarded the Victoria Cross (Arthur 2004, 258). Only a mile away and now in view, the Butte de Warlencourt would be his next objective.

On the 5th November, the 6th, 8th and 9th Battalions attacked positions on and around the Butte.

With the 4th and 6th Northumberland Fusiliers in support on each flank, this was very much an action of the men of the North East. The point of this 'Last Shake' was to secure the best of the terrain for the oncoming winter defensive season (Hart 2006, 483). Assaulting in atrocious weather conditions, Roland Bradford led the 9th's attack on the Butte itself while the 6th and 8th were launched towards German positions sited in depth. Although much of the Butte was taken it could not be held for more than a few hours. After two days of fierce fighting and a series of German counterattacks the Durhams had to withdraw at a cost of 907 killed, wounded or missing. Ultimately, the action failed to advance the British line any further (Hart 2006, 486-497).

Here it is worth considering the influence of two men. Roland Bradford has already been noted for his youth, leadership and bravery. A Territorial officer since 1912, he was a substantive Lieutenant and temporary Lieutenant Colonel when he commanded the 9th Battalion in 1916. Devoutly Christian, he was an officer who took every care for his men. While he demanded the highest of standards, it seems that he was respected by all ranks, including much older and longer-serving men. He had a very close affinity with his soldiers. The second is Captain Robert Mauchlen, MC, also of 9 DLI. Mauchlen was an accomplished artist, his wartime sketches and watercolours depicting many aspects of life on the Western Front (Moses 2001, 49-76). Mauchlen's portfolio includes a colour pencil sketch of the DLI attack on the Butte de Warlencourt².

It was under Lieutenant Colonel Bradford's direction that Captain Mauchlen designed a cross for 9 DLI which was constructed sometime in 1917 when the Battalion was in the area of Mercatel (near Arras and about 20 kms north of Warlencourt). Bradford's spiritual conviction and Mauchlen's artistic flair seem to have combined in helping to define the character of the Battalion, an effect that appears to have sustained the unit throughout the war.

The Butte de Warlencourt

The Butte de Warlencourt sits adjacent to the Albert – Bapaume road, an ancient route bisecting the Somme battlefield (Figure 3). The Butte is the most prominent of a series of mounds likely to have been created as part of a Roman observation or signalling network. Archaeological investigation of the site has produced some Gallo-Roman debris (Agache 1978, 246).

However, in 1916 the Butte possessed, in the minds of the combatants, more exotic and sinister connotations. An extract from a contemporary military report on the area states:

The Butte de Warlencourt is about 30 metres high – the diameter at its base is about 200 metres, and its summit about 20 metres. No building is erected on the Butte. It is built of chalky stone or earth, and its origin would appear to be the following one:-

[That] Gallic Chiefs were buried all around the Butte, in the fields, is proved by the discovery of tombs, and it was a custom that the tribes should throw a shovelful of earth over the place where the chief had been buried. In the course of time this constituted the Butte.

Digging has been made in order to discover the tombs, with a view to finding treasures, but it was not possible to carry out the work, as the ground of the Butte is very friable and gives way.³

In his war diary, Roland Bradford makes a telling observation, noting that the Butte 'became an obsession. Everybody wanted it. It loomed large in the minds of the soldiers in the forward area and they attributed many of their misfortunes to it' (Bradford, 1916). Modern historians still note its 'appropriately sinister appearance' (Hart 2006, 486) and its likeness in moonlight to 'some cold evil eye' (Macdonald 2013, 339).

An Ancient and Evocative Landscape

'Landscapes are culture before they are nature,' asserts Schama (1995, 61) 'constructs of the imagination projected onto wood and water and rock'. Furthermore, according to Ingold (2013, 80) a landscape that incorporates mounds can be even more active upon the imagination, exciting a range of responses, valid or otherwise, in the human psyche. Often assumed to be an ancient monument (and especially by archaeologists), a mound stimulates a desire for exploration, even excavation, and it has tantalising associations with memory.

These trench art crosses have done something more than simply coincide with landscape, an ancient mound and its associated lore (Figure 4). We are actually presented with complex expressions of identity and appropriation. Warlencourt bestows a physical and metaphorical palimpsest where spirituality and history are negotiated through layers of archaeology. While we

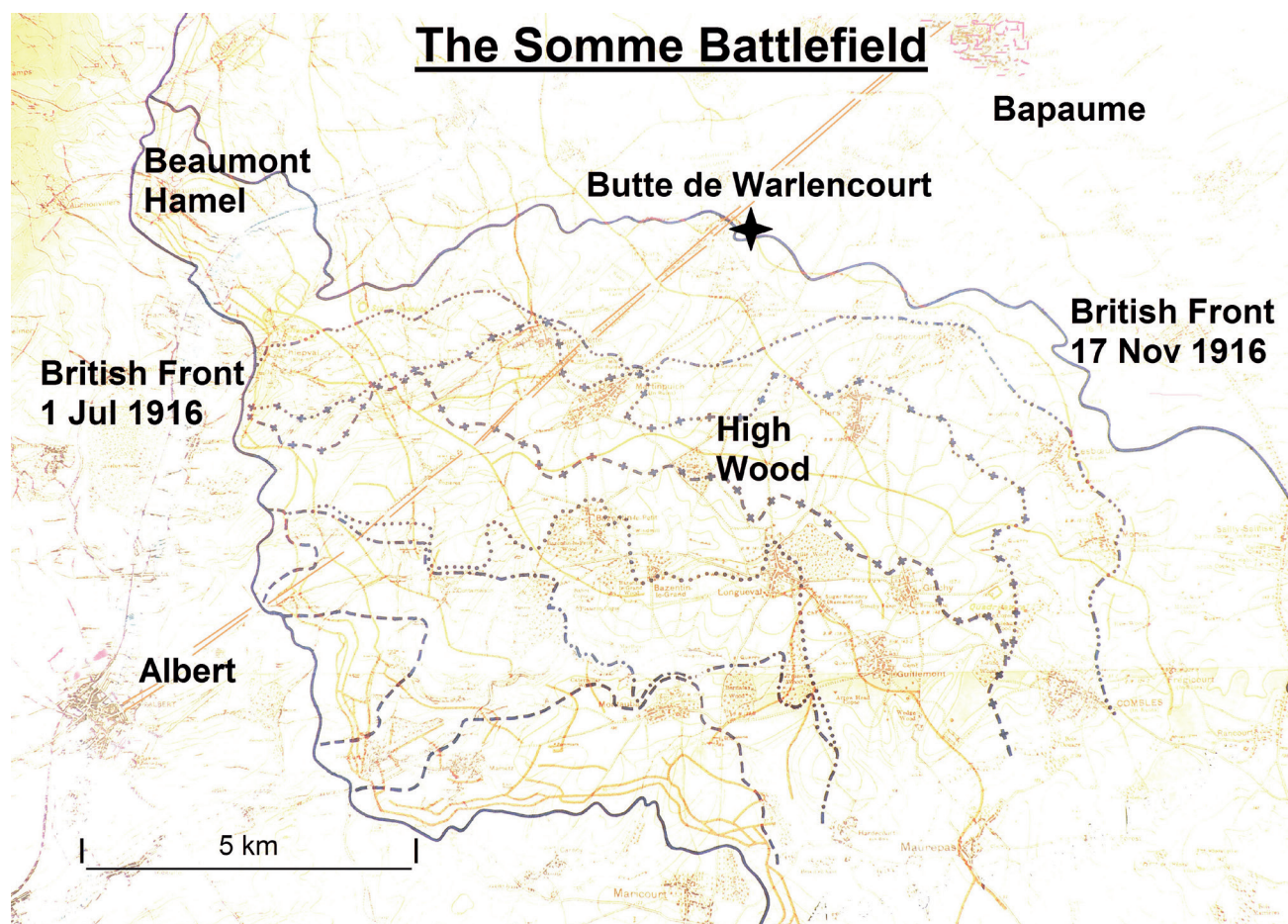


Fig 3

Annotated map of part of the British sector of the Somme. Blue lines mark the British advances. From Earl Haig's *Despatches*, 1919, J M Dent and Sons (Ordnance Survey).

do have textual sources on which to draw (though they are perhaps relatively scant), we also have an important array of material culture and symbolic signifiers. The bare facts of events (recorded history) combine with shifting archaeological and human relationships which are infused with the themes of the Gallo-Romanic period, Christianity, the First World War and its aftermath.

Archaeological and documentary sources can often be in tension. Such tensions have been explored in other landscapes (Moreland 2007, 41-43), where oral tradition, connections with the dead of antiquity, and contemporary beliefs and values each play their part. Moreland (*ibid*), in discussion of a Bronze Age barrow at Wigger Low in Derbyshire refers to the "making of an eloquent statement" when that feature was used for 7th-century burials, thus making the recent dead contiguous with the ancients. The Butte de Warlencourt probably houses no formal battlefield burials but it will certainly contain the remains of many missing soldiers, both Allied and German. The potency of the crosses is

reinforced by their temporal and physical immediacy with the dead.

The Butte provides us with some very important photographic illustrations of the Western Front. Complementing Captain Mauchlen's sketch and Bradford's own accounts are images in the Imperial War Museum's collection, the most evocative being that showing the Butte topped with a collection of crosses, prominent being a Celtic-style cross similar to that now in Durham Cathedral (Figure 4). The photograph is redolent of Calvary, an association that is unlikely to have been lost on Roland Bradford. Roadside Calvaries had long been a characteristic of these French landscapes and during the Great War the image of the cross was potent both as a talisman and as a memorial (Saunders 2003a, 132-134). The Butte memorial crosses perhaps go even further, conceptually and physically resurrecting and reasserting the Calvary.

As well as affirming the brooding nature of the mound and the conditions under which the fighting took place, the Imperial War Museum photographic



Fig 4

The Butte de Warlencourt, September 1917. (French Official Photographer, ©IWM Q 78163 <http://www.iwm.org.uk/collections/item/object/205322923>)

archive also shows that the site was becoming an important focus for commemoration as well as a point over which the former battlefield could be surveyed. It attracted a visit from King George V who recorded his own fascination with the materiality of conflict and war trophies, noting in a letter “I picked up these three shrapnel bullets on the Butte de Warlencourt on July 13th, 1917” (WS 2). The Butte also became a source of inspiration for the War Artist William Orpen in 1917, and in the following year a 1:56 scale model was created in the Imperial War Museum. The model even contains earth sourced from the Butte (WS 3). The influence of the Butte and its memorials on contemporary attitudes to remembering war should be seen in the original aspirations for the Imperial War Museum, that of presenting the concept of war itself as dead (Reynolds 2013, 209-210).

Lieutenant Colonel Bradford's personal reflections on the Butte deserve closer scrutiny and some credit. He was unconvinced about the strategic value of the Butte but accepted that such reservations he held may have been ‘only the narrow view of the Regimental Officer’ (Bradford 1916). It had been dubbed a miniature Gibraltar, thus, according to Bradford, prompting an attack that ‘was one of those tempting, and unfortunately at one time frequent, local operations which are so costly and which are rarely worthwhile’ (Bradford 1916). Bradford's ambivalence towards the Butte as a worthy military possession contrasts with his use of it as a place of commemoration. It is a place from where the surrounding terrain can be viewed and, in turn, the eyes of local observers will be drawn naturally towards it. Clearly it was an ideal candidate for Christian symbology (Saunders 2003b, 12).

The tradition of *sacri monti* and Calvaries is a long one in France, endowing the physical tumulus with a range of architectural works and spiritual ambitions. Illuminating is the story of Mont Valérien, now in a Paris suburb, but in the early 17th century a site that would have provided a stylised Calvary and an appropriate site for demonstrations of piety by the European élite. Originally intended to provide as many as fifteen chapels and nine ‘stations’ to Calvary, it was ultimately a more modest place but one heavily patronised by society. Over the centuries, Mont Valérien served variously as a focus for devotion, notoriety and political statement (Schama 1995, 439-442). The aspirations of Roland Bradford and his contemporaries may have been less grand and more spontaneous than those of Cardinal Richelieu and the grand vicaire Hubert Charpentier in 1633, but both the Butte and Mont Valérien speak of agendas of personal belief, control, and, perhaps, subversion. In the more secular 21st century, neither has managed to retain its visual affinity with Calvary.

The Psychology of Landscape and Place

The various responses to the Butte, cognitive or subliminal, may be better understood within theories related to a concept described as panoptical surveillance. The Panopticon was a scheme for control and observation deemed particularly appropriate for institutions such as prisons. Designed by the 19th-century social reformer Jeremy Bentham, it advocated the construction of circular buildings with cells in the outer wall, all of which could be observed from a central tower. Elemental to the design was the potential omniscience of the observer while those in the cells were unable to tell when they were actually under surveillance. Such schema have been seen by philosophers such as Foucault as at the heart of the exercise of power in a range of state institutions, including the army (Elliott and Lemert 2014, 116-117).

While we cannot interrogate the protagonists of 1916 to test the theory of panoptical surveillance, the limited contemporary records and photography tend to affirm its relevance. In Figure 5 we have a sense of the brooding nature of the Butte, seen in the background while Australian soldiers work on a small rail trackway. Photographed in March 1917, shortly after its abandonment by the Germans, it has yet to be adorned with its crosses (thus an act not quite ‘immediately after’ the attack as asserted in the Durham Cathedral scroll).



Fig 5
The Butte de Warlencourt. March 1917. (Lt Ernest Brookes, © IWM Q 108229 <http://www.iwm.org.uk/collections/item/object/205073412>)

However, study of the more recent ‘Troubles’ in Northern Ireland affirms how powerful the concepts and effects of surveillance and control can be. Referring to military observation towers placed on hill tops across the South Armagh countryside (often described as ‘bandit country’), a resident observed ‘[y]ou were constantly aware that they were looking down on you... They could look right into people’s homes and workplaces... eavesdropping on and looking into people’s lives’ (Graham, 2007, 48). The soldier’s perspective differed slightly and was less personal, yet is equally illuminating. ‘You could see all over the place... monitor the border, making sure there wasn’t anything dodgy going on... generally keeping an eye on things, especially patrols that were out’ (West 2007, 55). Even as modern stand-off surveillance technology might have negated the need for such a physical presence, the towers persisted as a physical manifestation of presence and control (Graham 2007, 51).

The Complexity of Landscape

The DLI crosses sat within, and now reference, a landscape that is multi-vocal. Bradford and Mauchlen were aware of the Butte’s archaeological significance, even if the assessments of 1916 were rather more exotic than would be offered today (Agache 1978). It is also reasonable to assume they would have been attuned to the contemporary debates surrounding science and religion which often sat uncomfortably with tradition and people’s negotiation with their surroundings. A striking literary example comes from Thomas Hardy’s *The Return of the Native*, published in 1878. The novel’s plot is played out against the doleful Wessex landscape

of Egdon Heath and especially the ancient tumulus of Rainbarrow. The protagonists’ fortunes are mediated through ancient tradition, folk lore, the strictures of Christianity, and prevailing social conventions. Central is the influence of Rainbarrow. Reconciliation over tragedy is achieved with a final appropriation of the barrow and its metaphorical exorcism. The barrow ultimately becomes the benign site for the returned native in his new career as itinerant preacher. The parallels with the Butte de Warlencourt in 1916 seem more than coincidental. That Hardy would have been the reading of officers such as Bradford and Mauchlen may be confirmed by Siegfried Sassoon, serving in the same theatre in 1916. Of *The Return of the Native*, read in July 1916, he says “The words fitted my mood” (Sassoon, 1965, 79).

More scholarly grounding of landscapes, their vocabulary and associations with memory and violence, adds weight to the contention that the DLI crosses grew from and added to the narrative of the Butte and its environs. The rhetoric of landscapes can be formidable, depending upon how they have been shaped by nature and human intervention, and the more so when they become landscapes of memory, such as Verdun and its lifeline in 1916, the Voie Sacrée, with its helmeted route markers (Whiston Spirn 1998, 22, 59). Indeed, Mont Valérien’s landscape, and its lost Calvary, was itself redefined, if not resurrected, with a cemetery for America’s dead of the First World War (*ibid*, 59).

Landscapes are multi-faceted, stimulating physical and sensory interactions, in a symbiosis of people and place (Roe 2014, 191-200). This perspective from a landscape planner such as Roe may help us better understand the emotional, spiritual, and possibly institutional dynamics behind the DLI crosses. Their primary function was to memorialise, but their impact on the landscape may have been much more profound. War implants new connotations on the land (Saunders 2002, 106). As Colombo and Schindel (2014, 1-17) suggest, violence ultimately affects space and memory. If space ‘is increasingly held to be both produced by, and productive of the social’ and demands more scholarly work (*ibid*), then the designs of Bradford and Mauchlen, and those who removed their crosses in 1927, may offer some contribution.

The Crosses

The crosses themselves deserve closer consideration. Their translation to Durham would have been a

significant Regimental and regional event. However, it seems that they were received in the various churches with differing degrees of ceremony and formality. Oddly, there is a lack of archival evidence regarding the most ornate, and arguably most important, of the crosses, that which now stands in Durham Cathedral. No faculty for its erection can be traced nor is there anything to suggest when the cross may have been dedicated. Conversely, the cross of the 6th Battalion was formally processed from the chancel at St Andrew's to the War Memorial Chapel, on 26 June 1927, where the Honorary Colonel, 6 DLI, entrusted it for ever as a memorial to those who fell at Warlencourt. That cross was dedicated by the Bishop of Durham (St Andrew's 1927). The Faculty (Durham Diocesan Registry 1927) notes that the cross was placed in the church at the request of the unit, having been brought to England in the autumn of 1926 after previously being 'exposed to all the varying climatic conditions of Northern France'.

The Gateshead cross to the fallen of 9 DLI in September and 1 October (Figure 6), and now in the DLI Museum store at Spennymoor, can be seen as a prototype for the Warlencourt crosses. It was erected during a lull in the fighting preceding the assault on the Butte. This is evidenced by a sketch initialled by Robert



Fig 6
The cross commemorating the fallen of 9 DLI 15 and 19 Sep and 1 Oct 1916 in the DLI Museum before its closure. (Author. Kind permission DLI Museum.)

Mauchlen, dated Oct 1916, and annotated "This is a drawing of the cross which we erected to our friends who were killed during the Great Advance", and signed by Roland Bradford. This cross memorialises men lost in Bradford's first major actions as Commanding Officer and the encounter in which he won his VC. (It is worth noting, however, that Bradford's VC was not actually gazetted until 24 November.) The trefoiled arms and head, the positioning of the regimental crest, the lettering, and the employment of the motto *Dulce et decorum est* seem common to the three later monuments and appear to have established an informal regimental pattern. Indeed, a letter written by Lt Col E G Crouch in 1917 (Bradford's second-in-command at Warlencourt) refers to the erection of a regimental pattern cross at Bradford's own grave at Hermies (Crouch 1917), following his death in action at Cambrai hardly three weeks after his promotion to Brigadier. Bradford was the youngest British officer to command a brigade in either world war (Holmes 2004, 208).

The crosses have more recently acquired a further important dimension in the North East's engagement with the war. In 2006, in commemoration of the Somme's 90th anniversary, they were reunited and displayed in the Durham Light Infantry Museum, along with items related to some of the soldiers who fell at Warlencourt (WS 7). The event was repeated in 2016 with the Warlencourt crosses brought together for display in Durham Cathedral throughout the Somme's centenary from 1 July – 20 November 2016 (WS 4).

The Crosses as Artefacts

As pieces of trench art, the crosses affirm levels of skill and dexterity in working with wood that might not be apparent in the general wartime outputs of regimental pioneers and sign writers. Furthermore, the sanctioned use of this material may have been seen as representing a wider tacit approval of the transformation of war matériel into trench art. The ability to scrutinise them as artefacts is now constrained partly by their display. Two are fixed to walls of parish churches and the third in Durham Cathedral sits in a spiritual and emotive context which demands respect.

However, visual examination of the crosses presents some important detail. The 6th Battalion cross retains a small white metal plaque at its top, reading GRU, for the Graves Registration Unit of the Imperial War Graves Commission whose function was to record details of burials (WS 5). The 8th Battalion cross clearly

once bore a similar panel. However, that in Durham cathedral bears no evidence of GRU recording. The anomaly is difficult to explain and we cannot know why the GRU would have registered the crosses; they did not mark burials, at least not in the formal sense. Perhaps the error was realised but the GRU plaques were not removed. Or the GRU may have had other plans for the disposal of the crosses that were not ultimately realised.

More significant are other markings, particularly those on the Durham Cathedral cross. It bears signs of battle damage and graffiti that seem to be absent from the others. The arm and stem have been gouged by shrapnel and the front and rear of the stem have been roughly inscribed, perhaps by a German hand (Figure 7). This may be attributed to actions after the Germans succeeded in retaking the Butte during their spring offensive in 1918 and when a German cross was also added to the Butte (Saunders 2003b, 12). This looks like deliberate defacement. However, we need to acknowledge that in general the sanctity of the crosses seems to have been respected and we should take care in ascribing motive to the originator(s) of this graffiti. It may represent the superimposition of authentic, if crude and humble, German commemoration. Furthermore, we need to acknowledge that the German cross does not appear to have survived the Butte's ultimate recapture by the Allies (*ibid*). The rear also retains faint signatures and dates from the 1920s, presumably left by veterans or next of kin during pilgrimages to the Butte. Described in neat and careful hands, they represent a potentially rich resource for the study of battlefield visits and pilgrimages in the years immediately after the war.



Fig 7
Graffiti on the Durham Cross. Note the Continental style of the numeral 1. (Author. By kind permission of the Chapter of Durham Cathedral.)

Noteworthy is the fact that the Cathedral memorial commemorates the fallen of all three battalions. (It is probably that to the left, and at right angles, to the others in Figure 4.) This begs the question as to the fate of the cross of the 9th Battalion, marking the dead of Bradford's own unit. That such a cross existed is proved by its photograph (Figure 8), suggesting that it is the Celtic-style cross second from the left, in Figure 4. It is ironic that the cross of Bradford's 9th Battalion either succumbed to the elements or was somehow lost, but there are other problems that need to be addressed. A simple issue, to the military mind, is the arrangement of the crosses. They do not appear to conform to regimental precedence, being loosely ordered from left to right, 9th, 6th and 8th, but this may approximately match the manner in which the battalions were deployed during the fighting. It is probable that there would have been some negotiation between the units as to who should have precedence in siting. We no longer know if the crosses were all erected on the same date and it is probable that 6th and 8th Battalions subsequently followed Bradford's lead in erecting their crosses. More puzzling is the existence of the cross commemorating all three battalions. Either *post* or *ante* the battalion crosses, it contextualises its companions. If it were the original monument it may have been deemed insufficient to the spiritual needs of men of each battalion desirous of their own cross. If it were a later addition does it represent collective appropriation of the Butte in the face of competing claims from each battalion? Or, given the erection of yet other regiments' crosses was this 'brigade' cross added to reassert Durham control and spiritual ownership of the Butte?



Fig 8
The 9 DLI cross on the Butte in July 1917. (Lt John Warwick Brooke, © IWM Q 3272 <http://www.iwm.org.uk/collections/item/object/205239069>)

The calculus of title and tenure of such sites of conflict can be bitter and emotive.

These valorised crosses, the dynamics of their installation and their translation to churches in Durham, add an important dimension to the understanding of both the locus of conflict and the concept of commemoration. It has been suggested that the battlefield is where three elements combine; the technology of war, the soldier, and the environment where the two engage in combat (Carmen 1999, 239). But the place of battle is also viewed through the lenses of memory and commemoration. Remote from their original context, the crosses are connected by oral and pictorial cues in their churches to the Butte de Warlencourt. Perhaps beyond Bradford's original intent, they remain a conduit for educational, emotional, and cultural negotiation with war. The extent to which they have been compromised by their removal from the Butte to the physical and spiritual sanctuary offered by the Diocese of Durham is debatable. They remain multi-valent relics of war.

A Lesson from Contemporary Times

An event from 2015 is especially illuminating, particularly for those anticipating that a narrative centred on the army, the church, and perhaps the most studied battle of modern times should be a well-documented and ordered affair.

On 13 March a service of commemoration marking the end of British military operations in Afghanistan was held in St Paul's Cathedral. During the service, in an act not dissimilar to that in St Andrew's in 1927, a trench art cross made from shell cases was paraded to the altar where it was blessed by the Archbishop of Canterbury (Figure 9). The cross was made in Camp Bastion, Afghanistan, where it sat atop a memorial plinth and was the focus for individual and collective acts of remembrance. It now resides at the National Arboretum Memorial in Staffordshire (WS 6).

The cross can no longer be attributed to its original maker, even after only a few years of existence. A number of such crosses were made and, as part of the military draw down and withdrawal operation, attempts were made for their appropriate disposal. These spontaneous creations were perpetuating the traditions of commemoration displayed on the Western Front. Some, unfortunately, had been discarded as rubbish. Others have been sent to military bases or individual regiments (Greenwood, pers comm, 2015).



Fig 9

The Bastion Cross in St Paul's Cathedral. (Graham Lacdao. With kind permission St Paul's Cathedral, © Cathedral Chapter, St Paul's)

As with the 9 DLI cross at Warlencourt, their *in situ* existence was transient. The true biography of the Bastion cross presented to the country in an act of national remembrance is far from secure. It seems that the fog of war can drift well beyond the battlefield. We might assume that the sentiments of the Bastion craftsman and those orchestrating the service of remembrance in St Paul's would coincide, but we cannot be certain.

Conclusion

The selection of wood as a medium for religious commemorative symbols during the First World War is hardly unusual. However, even if it arose partly out of convenience, the use of military timbers and crates was, for the DLI, an important part of the narrative of the Butte de Warlencourt memorials. Equally, the military artistic mind and artisanal hand involved in their design and construction express an intimacy that is not immediately apparent. The DLI crosses must be read as more than displaced relics with little context beyond the faded memories and commemoration of the actions of one regiment (important as that may be) in a war which took the lives of almost three quarters of a million British soldiers.

The inspiration for the crosses may have been Bradford's, a courageous leader and a very religious man. However, his concept of artistic memorial clearly gained

traction, not just across the other battalions of the DLI but in those other units and nations who added crosses of their own. Each DLI cross bears its unique blend of text, motif, and material while achieving a degree of regimental common identity. In style they may be seen as artistically conventional and yet they suggest an element of the institutionally subversive. We have no proof that the crosses were erected with formal sanction beyond the authority of an officer who was something of a rising star in the Army's command, and we can only guess at how the materials were acquired, although they may not have been in short supply. What official recognition they enjoyed is also difficult to establish. The War Graves Commission recorded their existence but there seems to have been no attempt to provide for their post-war protection and preservation. Their status was ambivalent.

The crosses certainly contributed to the subliminal power that the Butte was able to exercise. They were a statement to and for the dead. But they also allude to agendas of the frailty of decision-making in war. And they evoke a sense of appropriation; that of the avowal of the Durhams' right of ownership as well as that of Christianity over paganism. In that context, King George's visit in July 1917 may be viewed partly as a re-enactment of the piety displayed by the 17th-century Parisian élite at Mont Valérien, as well as a means of viewing battlefield gains and collecting souvenirs.

The creation and the perpetuation of the crosses throughout the war offer an important example of the legitimisation of trench art. Soldiers could see, and some were directly implicated in, the act of transformation of war matériel into a powerful alternative medium. As important, the crosses are a means by which we can test many of the hypotheses against which trench art is assessed. Combining the archaeological and the historical, we are able to establish provenance and context, elements often lost with much of the genre. It is possible to adduce motivation and means, fix the trench art to an event, and develop a coherent and credible biography for its life over the past hundred years. And whether it be in the defacement or the signing of the crosses while they stood on the Butte, or in the manner in which they are adorned in the 21st century, they are artefacts that continue to stimulate a human reaction.

Acknowledgments

I am very grateful for the kind assistance given by the Chapter of Durham Cathedral, the parishes of St Mary

and St Cuthbert, Chester le Street, and St Andrew, Bishop Auckland, and the Durham County Records Office.

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Endnotes

- 1 "Any item made by soldiers, prisoners of war and civilians, from war matériel directly, or any other material, as long as it and they are associated temporally and/or spatially with armed conflict or its consequences" (Saunders 2003a, 11).
- 2 Durham County Record Office D/DLI 7/920.
- 3 Information given by M. Parsi, Mason, on the Butte de Warlencourt. Report by W W T Torr, Captain G.S. III Corps, 5 Dec 1916. Durham County Record Office D/DLI 2/9/43 (2).

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